

Summary - Study Guide

Keep the central idea and major developments while removing details that do not change the overall meaning.

Learning goal

Choose or write a concise summary of a whole passage or a section without adding new claims.

1. What a summary does

A summary gives the reader the **main idea plus the most important supporting developments**. It is shorter than the original because it removes details that are useful but not necessary.

2. Main idea vs. summary

Main idea	Summary
The single central point	The central point + major supporting developments
Usually one sentence	May require more than one idea
Answers: "What is the passage mainly saying?"	Answers: "What do I need to know to understand the whole passage?"

3. How exam-style questions ask it

- Which statement best summarizes the passage?
- Which choice best summarizes paragraphs 3-5?
- Which statement best restates the main development in this section?

4. The four-step method

1. **Find the main idea.**
2. **Choose the major developments.** What changes, evidence, result, problem, response, or conclusion is necessary?
3. **Remove minor detail.** Names, examples, exact statistics, and side facts often disappear unless they are essential.
4. **Check for added claims.** A summary cannot introduce an opinion, prediction, or cause the passage never gives.

5. Long-passage strategy: compress by section

For a long passage, summarize paragraphs before summarizing the whole text.

Write a 3-6 word note for each section: *problem* → *pilot* → *results* → *limitation* → *next step*. Then combine only the sections needed to explain the overall passage.

6. Common summary traps

Trap	What it looks like
Too broad	States a general topic but misses what actually happened or was argued.
Too narrow	Summarizes one paragraph or example instead of the whole passage.
Detail-heavy	Lists several correct facts without showing the larger relationship.
Adds a new claim	Includes an opinion, recommendation, cause, or prediction not established by the text.
Misses a key relationship	Keeps the pieces but loses how they connect, such as problem → response → result.

7. When two summaries both seem accurate

Prefer the choice that:

- covers the whole required section,
- keeps the central relationship between ideas,
- uses fewer unnecessary details, and
- does not make the passage sound stronger or more certain than it is.

8. Worked example

A neighborhood association converted an abandoned lot into a community garden. Volunteers removed waste, built planting beds, and created an irrigation system. Over several years, the garden expanded, supplied vegetables to nearby residents, and became a meeting place for community events.

Which statement best summarizes the passage?

- A. Volunteers built an irrigation system in an abandoned lot.
- B. Residents transformed unused land into a garden that now provides food and serves as a community space.
- C. Community gardens are the best use for all abandoned lots.
- D. The garden grew vegetables after volunteers removed waste.

Best answer: B. A and D are accurate but too narrow. C adds a recommendation the passage does not make.

9. Diagnostic help

- **Your summary includes too many details:** ask whether the passage would still make sense without each detail.
- **Your summary is too vague:** include the main change, result, or relationship - not just the topic.

- **You miss section-summary questions:** ignore the rest of the passage and map only the paragraphs named in the question.

10. Quick check

Several companies tested four-day workweeks. Some trials reported lower stress and fewer resignations while productivity remained similar. Researchers caution that longer studies are needed because industries differ in staffing and customer demand.

Which statement best summarizes the passage?

- A. Four-day workweeks always increase productivity.
- B. Shorter workweeks may provide employee benefits without reducing productivity, but more research is needed across different workplaces.
- C. Workers dislike five-day schedules.
- D. Researchers study many industries.

Answer: B. It keeps the reported benefits and the important limitation.

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